startup RLM, too, need their slice of the pie. Moreover, an expansionist BJP—the one with the veto—isn't too keen to cede Nitish 115 seats this time.

WANING BUT BRIGHT

The BJP still feeds off Nitish's caste/gender base and acceptability. That political capital flowed from his ability to aggregate votes from groups not aligned to either the BJP or the RJD: Kurmis, Kushwahas, a swathe of Extremely Backward Classes. This social coalition has largely held over the years, but is now waning. Younger voters are less invested in his legacy, and fatigue chips away at his image as the state's moderniser. The dilemma for the BJP is whether to risk imposing too harsh a numerical definition on this. If so, how harsh? For the JD(U), too, it's a stark choice: should it accept a reduced seat share and risk shrinking into irrelevance, or resist the BJP's push—and risk rupture?

Takeaways

- **Nitish Kumar is fighting to keep his share of 115 seats, of the 243, from 2020. The BJP wants to go up from 110**
- **The tricky variable is Chirag Paswan. Even if he settles for 20, that trims everyone's pie**

Chirag, meanwhile, appears as a waxing crescent. At 5 per cent of the electorate, his base—Paswans clustered along central-south Bihar—will never alone suffice to make him king. But that vote bank floats independent of Nitish's. For the NDA, having them stacked atop each other makes sense. Yet, Chirag's lack of harmony with Nitish—personal and political—means reconciling to a basic internal instability. Having him go rogue, contrariwise, doubles the X-factor posed externally by the likes of Prashant Kishor. It's a riddle worthy of a Panchatantra. Or quantum math. ■

KARNATAKA

Sidda Greenlights Paper Ballots

The 'vote *chori*' chorus raises its pitch. Karnataka to ditch EVMs and revise voter rolls for local body polls

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

BALLOT PAPER, NOT EVM. That's the line Karnataka's ruling Congress is now toeing. It may be a leap across a tangent from Rahul Gandhi's expose—of 'vote *chori*' via electoral rolls. As allegations go, dubious voter lists are a different matter from rigged EVMs. But the two were fused into one general vote of no confidence when, on September 4, a state cabinet meeting chaired by CM Siddaramaiah recommended the use of ballot paper for all upcoming local body elections, including the long-overdue municipal elections in Bengaluru. If it comes to pass, this may become the first such shift back to the old-style voting on paper on a big scale since 2001.

The Opposition BJP was caustic in response, accusing the Congress of taking India's silicon hub back to the "stone age". But the momentum comes from Rahul's dramatic press conference in August, where Karnataka was literally ground zero. While it made a larger point, the case study was as local as could be: within the Bengaluru Central Lok Sabha seat, which the Congress counted as an unexpected loss last year, Rahul's research team showed what seemed to be a glaring dubiety in as many as 1,00,250 votes in its Mahadevapura assembly segment.

Doubling down on the "complaints" on electoral rolls, the Karnataka cabinet has empowered the





HINDUSTAN TIMES

WRITING ON THE WALL Right, CM Siddaramaiah; below, paper ballots, not seen widely since 2001, all set to make a local comeback